



# The power of diversity in online communities

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Received: 13 September 2024 / Accepted: 25 August 2025  
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## Abstract

An increasing focus on diversity and inclusion initiatives can be observed in the marketplace with varying success in terms of consumer response. Online communities create a virtual space where consumers can interact independent of their self in the offline world. This creates a marketing opportunity to embrace diversity and the plethora of personas in the digital space. Our research focuses on the role of communicating membership diversity in attracting and importantly engaging new members in an online community. We conducted an online survey experiment with 3000 consumers across six European countries. We find that communicating membership diversity of an online community increases interest in joining this community. The increased interest in joining further increased engagement behavior. Diversity orientation is the main driver for this effect. We contribute to the literature by providing evidence of the positive effect of communicating membership diversity in online communities.

**Keywords** Diversity and inclusion · Consumer engagement · Online community · Diversity orientation

## 1 Introduction

Understanding the role of diversity and inclusion (D&I) becomes increasingly important in the marketing domain (Kipnis et al., 2021). Especially now, when some big companies are scaling back their D&I activities and other market participants may wonder about the effects of embracing such activities (e.g., Kipnis et al., 2021; Mukherjee & Althuizen, 2020). We follow Kipnis et al. (2021) in regarding

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D&I initiatives in marketing as activities that “*proactively and consistently promote advancement of diversity & inclusion for all marketplace participants.*” (p.144). Such activities pose a challenge for marketers, as evidenced by mixed market reactions. Some provoke positive engagement while others face controversy (Burgess et al., 2021; Jonsen et al., 2021). Major sporting brand Nike, for example, earned positive reactions for advocating equality among US communities with a major advertising campaign encouraging consumers to reject racism (The Washington Post, 2017). Beauty retailer Sephora was praised for broadening its assortment and training personnel to cater to underrepresented customer segments (Forbes, 2021). Toy giant Lego gained positive attention for featuring characters with hidden disabilities in its latest sets (The Guardian, 2024). Marketing efforts related to D&I, however, also sometimes fail (Hassan et al., 2025), such as pride campaigns that evoke the perception of rainbow-washing (Wulf et al., 2022; Zheng, 2021) or consumers’ rage in online forums after the introduction of a cake to celebrate the end of Ramadan by a Danish retailer (DR, 2018). This inconsistency underscores the challenge marketers face in designing effective diversity initiatives.

Pioneering marketing scholars have acknowledged the role that marketing can play in advancing D&I for decades (Henderson & Williams, 2013; Williams & Henderson, 2012). Advancing the understanding of racial marketplace discrimination (Grier et al., 2024; Harris et al., 2005), stigma (Crockett, 2017), or privilege (Johnson et al., 2017) has built the foundation of the academic discourse on D&I initiatives in marketing (de Ruyter et al., 2022; Park et al., 2023). A large share of this research is most concerned with the negative consequences for marketers when D&I initiatives fail or the negative consequences for consumers experiencing inequality and exclusion, calling for more focus on the positive aspects of engaging in D&I initiatives (Kipnis et al., 2021). While the management literature has established positive outcomes of diversity measures (e.g., Confetto et al., 2023; Jonsen et al., 2021; Nguyen et al., 2024), very few recent papers illustrate the benefits of engaging in D&I initiatives in marketing. Moreover, existing research on D&I typically focuses on the experiences of only one particular underrepresented group in the market, e.g., people with disabilities (Patrick & Hollenbeck, 2021), ethnic minorities (Dharod et al., 2013), or elderly consumers (Oeser et al., 2018). However, D&I-related initiatives may not only affect the intended target group, but also general consumers (i.e., those representing the majority of consumers, who do not belong to a traditionally underrepresented group) experiencing these initiatives (Jacobsen et al., 2025). This emphasizes the relevance of focusing on the general consumers’ response to communicating diversity.

Our research follows this line of thought in the context of online communities. Recent research has started to explore the role of diversity membership within online communities, focusing on gender stereotypes (Drenten et al., 2023) or the role of group heterogeneity on online community and brand commitment (Liao & Wang, 2020; Liao et al., 2020). We expand this line of research by focusing on the effect of membership diversity both on attracting new members and on engagement behaviors.

Online communities can take many shapes and forms in the marketplace, from brand communities to gaming, crowdsourcing, or digital interest groups (Drenten

et al., 2023; Gu et al., 2022). These online communities have in common that members can take on personas that are different from their offline selves, which allows for more diversity in online than offline communities (Pan et al., 2014). Understanding how communicating this membership diversity in online communities affects consumers' attraction and engagement is central to our manuscript, as it helps brands build meaningful connections, ultimately driving more effective marketing outcomes (Beckers et al., 2018; Blut et al., 2023). To address this, we conducted a large-scale online experiment with representative region samples from six European (EU) countries based on an existing online community that fosters local food networks (FOXLINK). The results of this study contribute significantly to the literature on consumer engagement within online communities, providing novel insight into how users' diversity orientation moderates engagement, thus providing a deeper understanding of the dynamics of heterogeneous consumer groups in digital spaces.

## 2 Theoretical background

### 2.1 Self-expression in online consumer communities

Online communities offer the opportunity to bring people together irrespective of their cultural background, skin tone, or social class, as communication usually takes place through avatars, which do not have to correspond to the real-life characteristics of the user. This aligns with the Proteus Effect (Yee & Bailenson, 2007), which suggests that the flexibility of self-representation in virtual environments can influence behavior and reduce real-world biases. These communities, therefore, allow for a space without stigma, discrimination, or privilege as opposed to real-life marketplaces (Crockett, 2017; Harris et al., 2005; Johnson et al., 2017). Prior literature demonstrates that consumers engage in self-expression through consumption and community affiliation (Belk, 1988; Berger & Heath, 2007). Additionally, individuals have a fundamental need for uniqueness (Snyder & Fromkin, 1977; Tian et al., 2001), which influences their attraction to diverse and inclusive online spaces (Schau & Gilly, 2003).

Previous literature on online communities has identified the possibility for self-expression as an essential aspect of online community success (Pan et al., 2014). Communicating membership diversity within an online community can therefore attract a broader range of individuals by signaling inclusivity and openness to different perspectives (Kierian et al., 2023; Liao et al., 2020). Based on these findings and in alignment with core works on individual self-expression (Belk, 1988), we assume that communicating the diversity of an online community increases the attractiveness of the community, because it implies openness to members of a broad range of social groups. We therefore hypothesize:

H<sub>1</sub>: Communicating membership diversity increases interest in joining the online community.

## 2.2 Consumer engagement in online communities

Consumer engagement in online communities is a vital component that drives the success and sustainability of these virtual spaces (Bauer & Grether, 2005; Othmani & Bouslama, 2015). We broadly define consumer engagement in online communities as the level of interaction, participation, co-creation, and connection that consumers have with a brand or each other within the online platform (based on Brodie et al., 2013; Dessart et al., 2015; Hollebeek et al., 2014).

The likelihood of engaging in an online community is influenced by an individual's initial interest in joining. An attractive online community, which allows for interaction free of real-life stigma and discrimination, should increase engagement following the Proteus effect (Yee & Bailenson, 2007). According to the Commitment-Trust Theory (Morgan & Hunt, 1994), early interest signals an emerging commitment to the community, which fosters engagement over time. From an engagement perspective, the Customer Engagement Framework (Brodie et al., 2011) argues that early interest serves as the foundation for sustained participation, especially in online communities. Based on this foundation, we propose:

H<sub>2</sub>: A higher interest in joining an online community increases engagement.

## 2.3 Consumer engagement in diverse online communities

Individuals feel included in groups with which they share identities (Oxoby, 2009) and social identification is therefore important to consider in relation to D&I. Following social identity theory (Tajfel, 1974), consumers will strive towards ingroups consisting of similar fellow consumers at the same time as distinguishing themselves from outgroups characterized by dissimilar consumers. Consumers will evaluate perceived similarity with ingroups and outgroups based on visible (e.g., gender) and more intangible (e.g., religion) factors (Fisk et al., 2018). By focusing on the common characteristics among ingroup members and the differentiating characteristics of outgroup members, a shared identity is formed in a community (Oxoby, 2009). While diverse consumers, identifying with distinct groups, may join and passively co-exist in an online community, active engagement poses an important challenge from a marketing perspective due to a potential lack of social identification (Pan et al., 2014). Through active community engagement, individuals might express views and opinions that oppose those of the shared identity of being part of the community (Liao & Wang, 2020). A more diverse community might therefore hamper active community engagement in the fear of exposing oneself to unspoken rules and norms of the community. A silent membership in an overtly diverse community might be the perceived safer option. In line with recent research and the core assumptions of social identity theory (Tajfel, 1974), we hypothesize:

H<sub>3</sub>: Online community engagement is lower in communities with higher levels of membership diversity.

The three hypotheses taken together suggest that membership diversity in online communities may have counteracting effects. On the one hand, diversity

promotes interest to join the community, as the community signals that it gives room for a range of different expressions of self. Interest, being a motivational factor, can also be expected to have a positive effect on engagement in the community. On the other hand, once one has joined the community, diversity may inhibit engagement because a low level of engagement appears like a safe option in a community where the unspoken rules and norms are less clear.

## 2.4 Individual diversity orientation and community engagement

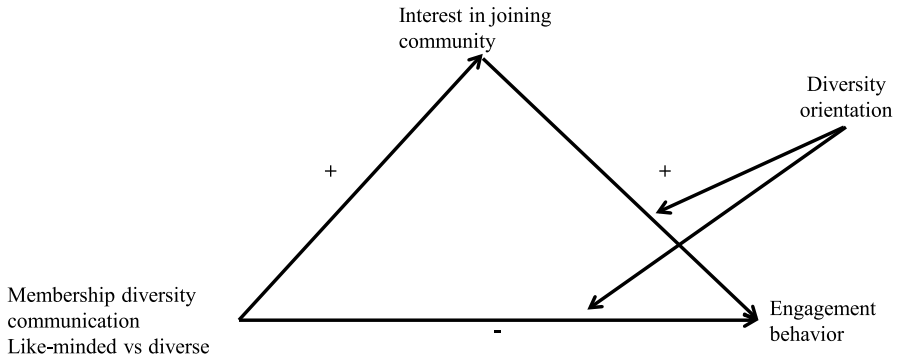
We suggest that individual diversity orientation is the deciding factor for which of the two opposing tendencies described in H1-H3 prevail. Despite the extensive research on community engagement (Brodie et al., 2011; Dessart et al., 2015) and the benefits of like-mindedness, there is a noticeable gap in understanding how both diversity within community membership and individual diversity orientation affect consumer engagement. Existing literature predominantly emphasizes the advantages of shared identity and common values in fostering a cohesive community (e.g., Kim et al., 2023), yet the implications of member diversity and the promotion of inclusivity remain underexplored. Addressing this discrepancy is crucial for developing a more comprehensive understanding of community dynamics and the factors driving consumer engagement across different types of communities (Brodie et al., 2011; Pan et al., 2014).

Communicating membership diversity indicates that the community values unique contributions and encourages self-expression, which can be particularly appealing to individuals seeking a space where they can be themselves without conforming to a homogeneous identity (Ribeiro et al., 2024). Research has shown that diverse communities are perceived as more innovative and dynamic, making them attractive to individuals looking for stimulating and varied interactions (Pan et al., 2014). The engagement in online communities, thereby depends not only on whether the community is diverse or like-minded, but also on the diversity-orientation of the individual member. We follow Miville et al. (1999) in defining diversity orientation as *'an attitude toward all other persons which is inclusive yet differentiating in that similarities and differences are both recognized and accepted; the shared experience of being human results in a sense of connection with people and is associated with a plurality or diversity of interactions with others'* (p. 292).

Consumers differ in their degree of diversity orientation in society (Fuertes et al., 2000), but it remains unclear how this trait affects their behavior within society. We assume that consumers who have a higher orientation toward diversity are more likely to engage with diverse online communities, as they may seek varied interactions. We therefore hypothesize:

H<sub>4</sub>: Diversity orientation moderates the relationship between communicated membership diversity and engagement.

We visualize our hypothesized relationships in our conceptual model in Fig. 1.



**Fig. 1** Conceptual model of interest in joining and engagement with online communities

### 3 Method and analysis

#### 3.1 Sample and recruitment

Ethical approval was obtained by the University's Research Ethics Committee. A market research agency was in charge of recruiting 500 respondents per region in six different regions in six EU countries (i.e., France, the Czech Republic, Germany, the Netherlands, Poland, and Spain<sup>1</sup>), representative in terms of gender, age, and educational background for the survey. The regions cover different urban and rural areas as well as differences in culture, which enhances the generalizability of our results. A total sample of 3,128 respondents was recruited (see sample overview in online Appendix A). Participants provided informed consent and were paid according to the local standards of the panel provider.

#### 3.2 Experimental design and procedure

The online survey experiment was set up as a simple 1-factor between-subjects design, where participants either received information to join a *diverse* interactive communication channel, or to join a *like-minded* interactive communication channel (Fig. 2). The flyers were based on the original recruitment flyer for the interactive communication channel (FOXLINK). After exposure, participants were asked to indicate their interest in joining the FOXLINK community and complete the manipulation check. On the next page, participants were exposed to an information post, which was taken from the FOXLINK platform (Fig. 3). They were asked to read the post and then indicate their evoked engagement behaviors, followed by the assessment of their diversity orientation.

<sup>1</sup> For transparency the regions are: Provence Alpes Cote d'Azur/FR, Central Bohemian Region/CZ, Lake Constance/DE, North Brabant/NL, Kuyavian-Pomeranian Voivodeship/PL, Valencia/ES. As these regions are less known to the average reader we refer to the country throughout the paper.



**Fig. 2** Experimental recruitment stimuli. Note: upper panel: diverse, lower panel: like-minded

### 3.3 Measures and analysis

We used three items based on Pan et al. (2014) to assess whether participants differentiate between the experimental conditions based on value dissimilarity on a 7-point Likert scale (Cronbach's  $\alpha=.64$ ) as a manipulation check. We assessed participants' interest in joining the community on a 7-point Likert scale anchored from 1 = Not at all interested to 7 = Very interested.

Following the definition of member engagement as "*customer's behavioral manifestations that have a brand or firm focus, beyond purchase*" (Van Doorn et al., 2010, p.254), we operationalized engagement as the number of discrete actions respondents said they would perform (reaction, comment, share, share with comment). Therefore, engagement behavior was assessed by counting the indications of performing different behaviors from leaving a reaction on the post (like, love, etc.), commenting on the post, re-sharing the content, sharing the content, adding one's own thoughts on, or not doing anything. We compiled these responses into a score ranging from 0 = no engagement behavior to 4 = all engagement behaviors.

The five items related to the cognitive dimension of diversity orientation (Fuertes et al., 2000) were measured on a 7-point Likert scale anchored from 1 = Strongly disagree to 7 = Strongly agree (Cronbach's  $\alpha=.78$ ). Moderated mediation analysis





**Fig. 3** Experimental engagement stimulus

(Hayes, 2017, model 15) was performed to understand the effect of the interest in joining the online community and the effect on engagement behavior, accounting for diversity orientation as a moderating factor. The variables of interest in joining and diversity orientation were mean-centered prior to analysis.

The data were pooled across countries based on both theoretical and empirical considerations. First, online community membership inherently transcends national boundaries, as digital interactions often occur without explicit awareness of other members' cultural backgrounds. Prior research on virtual communities suggests that engagement dynamics are influenced more by shared community norms than by country-specific cultural factors (Brodie et al., 2013). Given this, analyzing data at the aggregate level more accurately reflects the real-world functioning of online communities.

Second, our sampling approach ensured representation at the regional level rather than strict national representativeness. Treating each country as a distinct unit could be misleading, as the regional composition may not fully reflect national-level diversity. To validate the appropriateness of pooling, we conducted a comparative analysis of key variables across regions, which indicated similar trends irrespective of country. This suggests that the effects of diversity membership communication and engagement are consistent across contexts, justifying an aggregated analysis (see online Appendix B).



Finally, to account for potential contextual influences, the region was included as a control variable in our model. This approach allows us to capture any remaining variance that might arise from country-level differences while ensuring that the primary effects observed are generalizable across the broader sample. We report the results with and without these controls (Table 1, “Model without covariates” and “Model controlling for region”).

## 4 Results

### 4.1 Descriptive statistics and manipulation check

The manipulation check was successful in that participants receiving the information that the online community was like-minded perceived value dissimilarity to be significantly lower compared to the group receiving information that the online community was diverse ( $M_{\text{like-minded}} = 3.92$ ,  $SD = .88$ ,  $M_{\text{diverse}} = 4.04$ ,  $SD = .74$ ,  $t = -4.39$ ,  $p < .001$ ).

Participants' interest in joining the online community was significantly higher in the condition receiving information that the community was diverse ( $M_{\text{like-minded}} = 3.56$ ,  $SD = 2.03$ ,  $M_{\text{diverse}} = 4.62$ ,  $SD = 1.51$ ,  $t = -14.97$ ,  $p < .001$ ), thus confirming  $H_1$ . The engagement behavior score was also significantly higher in the diverse online community communication condition ( $M_{\text{like-minded}} = 1.04$ ,  $SD = .47$ ,  $M_{\text{diverse}} = 1.31$ ,  $SD = 1.02$ ,  $t = -7.44$ ,  $p < .001$ ), which does not support  $H_3$ .

### 4.2 Role of diversity membership communication on interest in joining and engagement

The first part of the moderated mediation analysis focuses on the effect of the diversity membership communication in recruitment on the interest in joining the online community. The results can be found in Table 1. The model confirms the positive significant effect of communicating membership diversity explicitly in recruitment on interest in joining ( $\beta = 1.06$ ,  $p < .001$ ), which is in line with  $H_1$ .

The moderated mediation analysis further shows that the communication of diversity in recruitment does not affect engagement directly, which is not in line with  $H_3$ . However, a higher interest in joining increases engagement behavior ( $\beta = .21$ ,  $p < .001$ ), which is in line with  $H_2$ . The interaction of diversity orientation and diversity membership communication does not influence engagement significantly. However, the interaction of diversity orientation and the interest in joining interact positively ( $\beta = .02$ ,  $p < .05$ ), supporting  $H_4$  partially. These findings suggest that a higher diversity orientation, paired with a high interest in joining, increases engagement behavior. We observe some differences across countries regarding interest in joining and engagement behavior; however, the described effect of diversity membership communication and diversity orientation remains unaffected whether or not we control for region.

**Table 1** Results of the moderated mediation analysis

|                                                                                             | Model without covariates | Model controlling for region |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|------------------------------|
|                                                                                             | Coefficient              | Coefficient                  |
| <b>Paths</b>                                                                                | $\beta$ (s.e.)           | $\beta$ (s.e.)               |
| <b>Diversity membership communication effect</b>                                            |                          |                              |
| Like-minded vs diverse $\rightarrow$ engagement behavior                                    | ns                       | ns                           |
| Like-minded vs diverse $\rightarrow$ interest in joining the community                      | 1.06 (.07)***            | .97 (.06)***                 |
| <b>Mediator effects</b>                                                                     |                          |                              |
| Interest in joining the community $\rightarrow$ engagement behavior                         | .21 (.01)***             | .20 (.01)***                 |
| <b>Moderator effects</b>                                                                    |                          |                              |
| Diversity orientation $\rightarrow$ engagement behavior                                     | .14 (.02)***             | .13 (.02)***                 |
| Like-minded vs diverse x Diversity orientation $\rightarrow$ engagement behavior            | ns                       | Ns                           |
| Interest in joining the community x Diversity orientation $\rightarrow$ engagement behavior | .02 (.01)*               | .02 (.01)*                   |
| <b>Index of moderated mediation effect</b>                                                  |                          |                              |
| Diversity orientation                                                                       | .02 (95%CI [.0001—.03])  | .02 (95%CI [.001—.030])      |
| <b>Covariates</b>                                                                           |                          |                              |
| Covariates <sup>†</sup> $\rightarrow$ engagement behavior                                   |                          |                              |
| Germany                                                                                     |                          | −0.05 (.06)                  |
| The Netherlands                                                                             |                          | −0.27 (.06)***               |
| Poland                                                                                      |                          | 0.02 (.05)                   |
| Czech Republic                                                                              |                          | 0.01 (.05)                   |
| Spain                                                                                       |                          | 0.19 (.05)***                |
| Covariates <sup>†</sup> $\rightarrow$ interest in joining the community                     |                          |                              |
| Germany                                                                                     |                          | −0.45 (.12)***               |
| The Netherlands                                                                             |                          | −1.04 (.11)***               |
| Poland                                                                                      |                          | −0.07 (.11)                  |
| Czech Republic                                                                              |                          | −0.26 (.11)*                 |
| Spain                                                                                       |                          | 0.43 (.11)***                |

Note:  $n = 3128$ \*  $p < .05$ ; \*\*  $p < .01$ ; \*\*\*  $p < .001$ <sup>†</sup>France is reference

## 5 Discussion and Conclusion

The main objective of this paper was to identify the role of diversity membership communication in attracting members for online communities and their subsequent engagement behavior. We hypothesized that while a higher degree of diversity in members can increase interest in joining the community, it could at the same time deter engagement. Our results do not bear this out. We find that a higher degree of diversity in members indeed increases interest in joining the community, and that

this interest carries over to a higher engagement as one of the most important measures of online community attractiveness. This is an important contribution to the stream of literature advocating for the benefits of engaging and embracing D&I initiatives not only on specific targeted groups (Kipnis et al., 2021), but on general consumers' response (Jacobsen et al., 2025). In addition, we contribute to the literature by showing how this effect is moderated by diversity orientation (Fuertes et al., 2000), i.e., interest in joining translates into engagement mainly for diversity-oriented consumers.

Our results are aligned with previous research in that we show that diverse online communities are more attractive for consumers to join (Liao et al., 2020; Pan et al., 2014). We further show that diversity orientation enhances the effect of interest in joining on engagement. This suggests that recognizing and valuing the different perspectives members bring from diverse backgrounds increases engagement (Dessart et al., 2015). At the same time, we find that diversity orientation does not affect the relationship between the diversity membership communication and engagement with the community's content. This indicates that diversity-oriented individuals engage more based on their general interest in the community, rather than the actual degree of diversity communicated.

## 5.1 Limitations

We acknowledge that our study faces some limitations that should be addressed by future research. First, we present the case of a hypothetical survey experiment, where we can only measure a proxy for engagement behavior. We do, however, use stimuli adapted from a real-world online community, which was active at the time of data collection, to match real-world applications as closely as possible. We used a self-reported measure of consumer engagement in the form of a behavioral checklist. Future work could triangulate survey responses with unobtrusive trace data. Field studies on observed engagement behavior in different online contexts would enhance external validity.

Moreover, interest in joining the online community was only measured with a single-item measure. Although this measure captures the explicit interest to join, it could have been combined with more implicit measures, e.g., time spent on the page, to provide a more advanced perspective on the interest to join the community. Whereas this study merged the cross-country samples, future research may explore diversity perception across countries more explicitly. In addition, the potentially moderating role of the type of online community or specific (potential) member characteristics could be relevant to explore.

## 5.2 Managerial implications

Our results suggest that marketers should embrace the diversity within online communities and use this strategy to increase the attractiveness of the community. This strategy seems to affect not only recruitment but also indirectly the level of

engagement of the members of the community. At the same time, a potential negative direct effect of diversity on engagement was not found. While some research found backlash associated with diversity marketing (Hassan et al., 2025; Kipnis et al., 2021), our research does not support this in the online community context. Our findings suggest celebrating diversity in the online community context. However, from a managerial perspective, note should be taken of the strong influence of interest in joining on engagement. Our research suggests that the relevance and purpose of the community is the strongest driver for engagement, which is enhanced through diversity orientation. The marketing activities for the community should therefore not only focus on the diversity of the community, but also on the purpose and values of it to ensure reaching those who are genuinely interested in order to stimulate engagement. Overall diversity emerges as a powerful marketing tool, which can be strategically utilized to maintain the value created by online communities.

**Supplementary Information** The online version contains supplementary material available at <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11002-025-09792-4>.

**Funding** Open access funding provided by Aarhus Universitet. This research was made possible by the project “FOX – Food Processing in a Box” funded by the European Union’s Horizon 2020 research and innovation programme (Grant Agreement No 817683).

**Data availability** Data will be made available upon request.

## Declarations

**Informed consent** Informed consent was obtained from all participants prior to study participation.

**Conflict of interest** There is no conflict of interest.

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